ClientFlow

Cold email that sends from your own mailboxes, at a pace they survive.

A business plan for ClientFlow: a subscription platform that lets small B2B teams and agencies run sequenced outbound email through mailboxes they already own, without burning the domains they depend on.

PREPARED
September 2026

STATUS
Pre-launch. Frontend built, backend specified.

Executive summary

ClientFlow is a cold email platform sold by subscription. Customers connect the Gmail or Outlook mailboxes they already own, upload a contact list, write a short sequence, and let the system send it across those mailboxes inside a daily ceiling. Replies, bounces and opt-outs stop the sequence automatically.

The product does not sell mailboxes, lead databases, or guaranteed inbox placement. It sells pacing and control: the mechanics that decide whether an outbound programme still works in month six. That focus is the position, and it is also the constraint — the plan below does not assume ClientFlow wins on feature count against larger, better-funded competitors, because it will not.

MODEL	TIERS	BLENDED ARPA	BREAK-EVEN
SaaS	**3**	**$66**	**3–8**
Monthly and annual subscription	$29 / $79 / $199 per month	At the assumed plan mix	Paying customers, at assumed costs

How to read the numbers in this document

Every financial figure here is derived from assumptions that are stated explicitly beside it. None of them is a forecast, and none is based on ClientFlow's own trading history, because there is none yet. Competitor prices are drawn from third-party reporting and are cited as such; they should be re-checked on each vendor's own pricing page before any decision rests on them.

What is already built

The complete frontend exists and runs: a marketing site, a customer workspace (campaign builder, contacts and CSV import, mailbox management with warm-up and capacity meters, a unified reply inbox, suppression list, analytics, billing), and a platform admin dashboard (revenue, accounts, subscriptions, campaign oversight, support queue, plan editor, audit log). It runs in demo mode against sample data, so it can be shown to a prospective customer or investor today.

The backend is fully specified but not written. The specification covers multi-tenant data isolation, the send engine, OAuth, billing webhooks, compliance headers and VPS deployment. It is the next piece of work.

The problem

Outbound email fails for mechanical reasons far more often than for creative ones. Three failures account for most of it, and all three are avoidable:

Failure	What happens	Consequence
Sending too much, too early	A domain that has never sent 20 emails sends 2,000 in a week.	Providers filter the domain. Every subsequent email suffers, including invoices and support replies.
Following up after a reply	The sequence sends step three to someone who already answered step one.	The sender looks automated, which is the one thing cold email cannot look. The conversation dies.
Mailing an unverified list	A quarter of addresses bounce because nobody cleaned the file.	Bounce rate crosses the threshold where providers stop trusting the sender at all.

Existing tools can all technically prevent these. In practice their defaults favour volume, because volume is what demos well and what the pricing page counts. ClientFlow's defaults favour survival, and the product says so out loud — including on the marketing site, which tells prospective customers that the platform will deliberately slow them down in month one.

Who this is for

Founders and small B2B teams selling a considered-purchase product, sending hundreds rather than hundreds of thousands of emails a month, whose company domain is also the domain their customers and investors email them on. The cost of burning it is not abstract to them.

Small lead-generation and recruiting agencies running outbound for a handful of clients, who need each client's mailboxes, lists and reporting kept separate but billed together.

Who this is explicitly not for

Teams sending scraped lists at six-figure monthly volume. They are the customers who generate complaints, damage shared sending reputation, consume support time, and churn when a cheaper tool appears. The bounce and complaint ceilings in the product are designed to make ClientFlow an uncomfortable place for them, and that is intentional rather than a limitation to be removed later.

Market and competition

This is a crowded market, and the plan should not pretend otherwise

Cold email sending is a mature category with several established, well-funded products competing largely on price and volume. A new entrant with the same feature set and no distribution has no reason to win. The strategy below therefore rests on segment focus and billing reach rather than on being a better sequencer.

Reported competitor pricing

The figures below come from third-party reviews and comparison sites published during 2026, not from the vendors' own pricing pages. Reported prices for the same plan differ noticeably between sources — partly because annual billing is often quoted as a monthly figure, and partly because these vendors change prices. Treat the column as a range, and verify before relying on it.

Product	Reported entry price	Pricing basis	Notable
Instantly	$30–$47 / month	Email volume	Unlimited mailboxes; lead database and CRM sold as separate subscriptions
Smartlead	$32.50–$39 / month	Workspace + volume	Unlimited mailboxes; deliverability testing and white-label are paid add-ons
Saleshandy	$25 / month	Workspace	Includes a lead finder; frequently cited as the lowest entry price
lemlist	$39–$79 / user / month	Per seat	Multichannel including LinkedIn steps; cost multiplies with team size

Two things follow. First, ClientFlow's proposed $29 entry price is competitive but not differentiating — it sits inside the existing band. Second, several competitors advertise unlimited mailboxes at the entry tier, so a mailbox-limited Starter plan will be compared unfavourably on a feature grid. That is a real objection and the answer has to be a reason to care about something other than the grid.

Where a new entrant can actually win

1. Local payment rails. Most competitors bill through international card processors. Founders and agencies in Nigeria and comparable markets routinely have cards declined by them. A platform that bills in local currency through a local processor removes a purchase barrier that no amount of feature parity addresses. This is the single most defensible advantage available here, and it is available specifically because of where the business is based.

2. A narrow first segment. Winning "cold email tools" is not possible. Winning "outbound for African B2B SaaS and agencies selling into Europe and North America" is a smaller, reachable target where the founder has context competitors do not.

3. Honesty as positioning. The category markets volume. A product that leads with what it will not let you do is memorable in a way a feature list is not, and it self-selects for customers who churn less.

Market sizing has been left out of this plan on purpose. Any total-addressable-market figure available for this category would be an unverified number copied from a vendor's marketing page, and it would not change a single decision on the next page.

How the business earns

Recurring subscription revenue is the whole model at launch. Everything else listed below is a later addition and none of it is assumed in the projection.

Primary: subscription tiers

Plan	Monthly	Yearly	Mailboxes	Contacts	Emails / month	Seats
Starter	$29	$290	2	2,500	6,000	1
Growth	$79	$790	10	25,000	40,000	3
Agency	$199	$1,990	50	150,000	250,000	15

Annual billing is priced at ten months for twelve. It is worth more than the discount costs: it converts a monthly churn decision into an annual one and moves cash forward, which matters more than margin when the business is small.

Why limits sit on volume and mailboxes rather than seats. Seat pricing punishes the agency customers who are the most valuable segment here, and it is the specific complaint that drives teams away from per-user competitors. Volume pricing also aligns the bill with the cost to serve, since sending is where the infrastructure cost actually sits.

Later revenue lines, not modelled

Line	Mechanism	Why it fits	When
Email verification credits	Usage-based, resold at a margin	Customers must clean lists anyway; doing it in-product removes a tool and reduces bounces the platform pays for	After launch
Done-for-you onboarding	One-off fee, roughly $200–$500	Domain, SPF, DKIM and DMARC setup is the hardest part of week one and the most common reason a trial fails	Immediately
White-label agency tier	Higher monthly price	Agencies pay for a client-facing dashboard in their own branding; competitors charge separately for this	Month 6+
Affiliate programme	Revenue share on referrals	The category's buyers are reached through operator newsletters and communities, not paid search	Month 3+

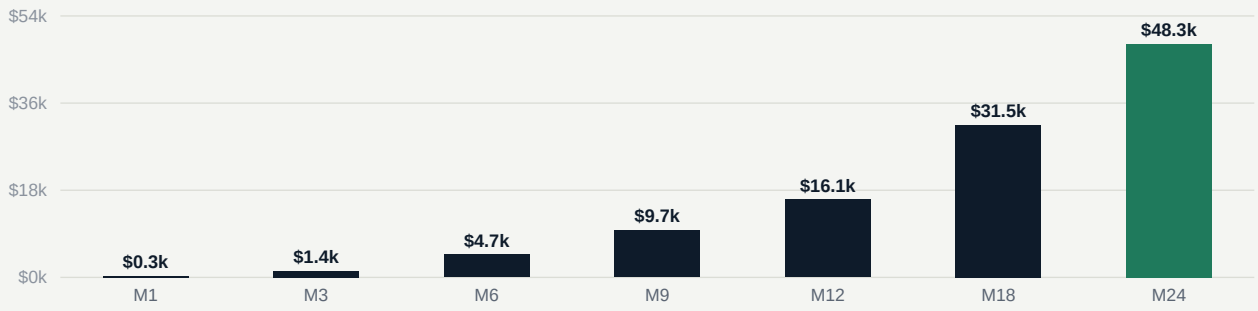
One revenue line deliberately excluded

Selling a lead database is the obvious adjacent product and most competitors do it. It is excluded here because the data is expensive to license, its quality is the single most common complaint in reviews of the vendors who sell it, and lists bought in-product are exactly what drives the bounce rates the platform exists to prevent. Selling the disease and the cure at once is not a coherent position.

Financial projection

Assumptions, stated plainly

Plan mix of 55% Starter, 33% Growth and 12% Agency, giving a blended ARPA of $65.90. Monthly customer churn of 6%. New paying customers rising from 4 in month one to 85 in month twenty-four. Every one of these is a guess. The churn rate in particular is a planning input, not an observation — self-serve SMB tools in this category are widely reported to churn heavily, but no verified figure specific to cold email software was found, and none should be invented. Re-run this model against real numbers as soon as there are twenty paying customers.



Period	New	Churned	Customers	MRR	Run rate
Month 1	4	0.0	4	$264	$3,163
Month 3	11	0.6	21	$1,391	$16,697
Month 6	23	3.1	72	$4,722	$56,662
Month 9	35	7.2	148	$9,721	$116,651
Month 12	47	12.6	244	$16,106	$193,271
Month 18	67	26.2	478	$31,514	$378,167
Month 24	85	41.4	733	$48,323	$579,876

The shape matters more than the values. Churn compounds against acquisition: at 6% monthly, roughly half of each cohort is gone within a year, so the business is running to stand still long before the numbers look impressive. If the real churn figure turns out to be 3%, the month-24 MRR is materially higher for exactly the same sales effort. Reducing churn is worth more than any acquisition tactic in this model, which is the argument for the conservative-defaults positioning.

Operating costs

Monthly, in the first year, at the volumes above. Infrastructure is genuinely cheap for this product because the send workload is spread deliberately rather than bursty.

Item	Estimate / month	Basis
VPS (4GB, 2 vCPU)	$25 – $50	Published pricing at mainstream providers; hosts the API, worker, MongoDB and Redis
Backups, off-server	$5 – $10	Object storage for nightly dumps
Domains and own mailboxes	$20 – $40	The company's own sending and support addresses
Transactional email	$0 – $15	System notices; free tiers cover early volume
Payment processing	~3% of revenue	Stripe's published US rate is 2.9% + $0.30 per successful card charge. Local-processor rates differ and must be confirmed directly.
Error tracking and uptime	$0 – $30	Free tiers are adequate below roughly 100 customers
Total, fixed	$50 – $145	Excluding the founder's own time

At the assumed $66 blended ARPA, fixed costs are covered by roughly three to eight paying customers. The business is not capital-intensive. Its scarce resource is founder time, and the largest unbudgeted cost is support — deliverability questions are hard to answer briefly, and every one of them lands on the same person until there is documentation good enough to deflect them.

Getting the first customers

Paid acquisition is not viable here. The category's search terms are contested by companies with far larger budgets, and a $29 entry price cannot absorb that cost of acquisition. The route in is narrower and slower.

Phase	What to do	Target
Months 1–2 First ten	Hand-recruit ten customers from the founder's own network and from communities where the segment already gathers. Onboard each one personally, including their DNS setup. Watch them use it. The goal is evidence and testimonials, not revenue.	10 paying
Months 3–6 Proof	Publish what the onboarding taught: domain warm-up, SPF/DKIM/DMARC, why a list bounces. Deliverability content is durable, ranks over time, and attracts exactly the buyer this product wants. Launch the affiliate programme.	40 paying
Months 7–12 Repeatable	Partner with small lead-generation agencies who resell under the white-label tier. One agency relationship is worth more than a dozen self-serve signups and churns far less.	150 paying

The trial is fourteen days without a card. That is a deliberate cost: it fills the funnel with people who will never pay. It is accepted because the product's value only becomes visible after a sequence has run for a week, and a card wall in front of that converts worse than the wasted trials cost.

What has to be true for this to work

Stated so they can be checked, rather than assumed quietly:

- Google approves the OAuth application. Without it, nothing ships.
- Ten people in the founder's reachable network will pay $29 a month for this. If that is hard, the positioning is wrong, and it is better to learn that in month one than month nine.
- Monthly churn settles below 8%. Above that, acquisition never outruns it at this price point.
- Support stays under roughly one hour per customer per month. Above that, the unit economics stop working long before the infrastructure does.
- Local-currency billing genuinely converts customers who would otherwise not buy. If it does not, the main differentiator is gone and the plan needs rewriting.

Features worth building, in order of leverage

Ranked by how much each one moves either acquisition or retention, not by how interesting it is to build. The first three are worth more than the rest combined, and the first two directly reduce the bounce rates the platform is otherwise penalised for.

Feature	What it does	Why it earns its place
Built-in email verification	Checks addresses at import: syntax, domain, mailbox existence. Rejects or quarantines the bad ones before they can be mailed.	Bounces are the single largest cause of a campaign failing, and the platform is what gets blamed. Sold as usage credits, it is also a margin line rather than a cost.
Domain and DNS setup wizard	Checks SPF, DKIM, DMARC and MX for the sending domain and tells the customer exactly what record to add and where.	This is where most trials die. Removing it converts trials that would otherwise churn silently in week one, and it deflects the support questions that consume the most founder time.
Inbox placement testing	Sends to a set of seed mailboxes across providers and reports where the message landed.	Turns deliverability from a feeling into a number. Competitors charge for this separately; including it at the Growth tier is a concrete reason to upgrade.
Warm-up network	Connected mailboxes send and reply to each other on a schedule to build sending history on a new domain.	Widely expected in the category and frequently listed first in competitor marketing. Its absence will be noticed on any feature comparison.
AI copy assistance	Drafts sequence steps and suggests merge fields from the product description and the target persona.	Not a differentiator any more, but its absence reads as dated. Cheap to add over an existing model API.
CRM integrations	Pushes replies and campaign activity into HubSpot, Pipedrive or a webhook.	The most common reason a team outgrows a standalone sequencer. An integration is far cheaper to build than a CRM and removes the exit reason.
White-label agency portal	Client-facing dashboards under the agency's own domain and branding.	The clearest upgrade trigger for the highest-value, lowest-churn segment, and directly monetisable as a tier.
LinkedIn as a sequence step	A manual task step that pauses the sequence until the user confirms a connection request or message.	Multichannel without automating a platform that bans automation. Low risk, and it closes the gap against per-seat multichannel competitors.
Shared inbox with assignment	Replies routed to a teammate, with status and internal notes.	Turns a single-user tool into one a team standardises on, which raises the switching cost.

What not to build

A lead database, an AI agent that sends without review, and anything that raises the sending ceiling. All three are visible in competitors' marketing and all three attract the customer segment this product is specifically designed to repel. Adding them would not be an expansion of the plan; it would be a reversal of it.

Risks

In rough order of how likely each is to end the business.

Risk	Why it matters	What reduces it
Platform dependency on Google and Microsoft	The entire product runs on OAuth access those two companies grant and can withdraw. Verification is required before launch and takes weeks. Scope policy has tightened before and can again.	Request only the minimum scope needed to send. Build reply detection behind an interface so IMAP can substitute for the Gmail API. Start verification the day OAuth works, not the week before launch. Support plain SMTP as an escape hatch.
Reputation damage from one bad customer	Cold email platforms attract senders who ruin shared sending reputation for everyone else on it.	Automatic pausing at bounce and complaint ceilings, enforced platform-wide and not switchable off by the customer. An oversight queue reviewed daily from day one, not added later.
Commoditisation and price pressure	Established competitors compete on price and volume, and several already advertise unlimited mailboxes at the entry tier.	Do not compete on the feature grid. Hold the segment focus and the billing advantage. Accept a smaller market.
Legal exposure on the customer's behalf	Cold email is regulated differently in every market. GDPR requires a lawful basis for processing; other jurisdictions have their own rules, including Nigeria's data protection regime.	Get the terms and privacy policy reviewed by a lawyer before the first payment — the versions in the repository are placeholders and say so. Enforce unsubscribe handling in the product rather than in the terms.
Single-founder concentration	One person holds all product, support and infrastructure knowledge. Illness or burnout stops everything.	Document the deployment. Automate backups and test a restore. Keep the stack boring enough that a contractor could pick it up.
Churn higher than modelled	The projection is sensitive to this above all other inputs.	Measure it from the first cohort. Interview everyone who cancels. Treat month-two retention as the primary metric, ahead of signups.

Build sequence

Ordered so that something is demonstrable at every stage, and so the slowest external dependency starts as early as possible.

Stage	Work	Done when
1	Express API, MongoDB, models, authentication, the organisation/user split	Two organisations cannot see each other's data, proven by an automated test
2	Contacts: CRUD and CSV import with column mapping and a rejection report	A messy real-world CSV imports cleanly and reports what it dropped
3	Google OAuth, token encryption, mailbox management. Submit for verification now.	A mailbox connects and its tokens are unreadable in the database
4	Campaigns and the send engine, running in dry-run mode	Pacing, rotation and the send window behave correctly in the logs, with nothing sent
5	Live sending to the founder's own addresses, ten at a time	Threading, merge fields and stop-on-reply all work end to end
6	Suppression, unsubscribe, and the required List-Unsubscribe headers	One-click unsubscribe stops every campaign for that address
7	Reply detection over IMAP	A reply cancels the remaining steps within one send cycle
8	Billing: checkout, customer portal, idempotent webhooks	Replaying the same webhook event twice changes nothing
9	Admin: metrics, oversight, audit log	A campaign over the bounce ceiling appears in the queue automatically
10	Microsoft Graph, then the white-label tier	Outlook mailboxes send alongside Gmail ones in the same campaign

The dependency that decides the launch date

Google's verification review for the sending scope runs on Google's timetable, not the build's. It is the only item here that cannot be accelerated by working harder, which is why it belongs at stage three rather than stage ten. Reply detection over IMAP exists in this plan specifically to avoid the restricted-scope review, which additionally requires an annual third-party security assessment. Confirm the current requirements and costs with Google's own documentation before budgeting for them.

A closing note on this document

Nothing here is a projection in the sense a bank would use the word. There is no trading history to project from. What this document does is state the assumptions clearly enough that they can be tested and replaced, name the risks that are most likely to end the business, and set out what has to be true for the model to hold. The numbers will be wrong. The point is that when they turn out to be wrong, it will be obvious which assumption failed.